



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Should chess players invest in their diet?

Chess isn't just about strategy; it's a **mental marathon**. And like any marathon, your performance depends on what you're feeding your body and mind.

Imagine this: you're at the final move of a chess championship. The crowd holds its breath as you hover over your rook. Your brain is firing on all cylinders, but then — a split-second fog. What went wrong? For many chess players, the answer lies in what fuels the brain: their diet.

At 18, Gukesh Dommaraju is dominating global chess with unmatched focus and endurance. While his secrets remain private, one truth stands out: a sharp mind starts with the right fuel. For stars like Gukesh, smart choices off the board mean smarter moves on it.

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Ever heard the wild claim that chess players burn 6,000 calories a day during tournaments? It's a fun headline, but it doesn't add up. While intense mental activity does burn more energy than resting, it's far less dramatic than the myth suggests.

Studies reveal that prolonged mental exertion increases energy

expenditure by 20-30 per cent, adding roughly 200-300 extra calories per day — not 6,000.

So, unless you're snacking like a linebacker, overeating based on this misconception can leave you sluggish or distracted when you need to focus most.

Why diet is the secret weapon for chess players

Your brain might only weigh about 1.4 kilograms, but it's a calorie-guzzling machine, using 20 per cent of your daily energy.

To perform optimally, it needs the right fuel — and no, energy drinks and sugary snacks don't count.

Here's how nutrition directly impacts chess performance:

1. Sharper memory and decision-making: Foods like dark chocolate, blueberries, and green tea contain polyphenols that enhance memory and decision-making — skills every chess player needs.

Ryan's Tip: Opt for dark chocolate with 70 per cent cocoa for brain benefits. Replace chai with green tea and a dash of lemon; add tulsi for an Indian twist. Pair with two small squares (25g) of dark chocolate for a

smart snack.

2. Steady focus: High-glycemic foods (like candy) might give a quick boost but lead to crashes. Low-GI foods, like oats and lentils, provide slow-releasing energy, keeping you sharp for longer.

Ryan's Tip: Start your day with masala oats (30 g) for sustained energy.

3. Calm under pressure: Magnesium, found in nuts and spinach, helps reduce stress and improve composure — a must for handling nerve-wracking endgames.

Ryan's Tip: Add 10-12 almonds (25g) daily or blend spinach (50g), banana, and coconut water for a calming drink.

Fun fact: Magnus Carlsen's fuel

Speaking of champions, did you know that Magnus Carlsen prefers eating light and avoids sugar during matches?

He's been spotted munching on nuts and sipping water — a stark contrast to the myth of chess players indulging in junk food.

Turns out, even the world's best know that clean eating equals clear thinking.